

MEASLES:

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

VA Ann Arbor Health Care System, 4/21/25

What is measles?

Measles is an infectious disease caused by the measles virus. It is very contagious. At first, measles causes nonspecific symptoms like fatigue, cough, and high fever. After a few days of symptoms, patients break out in a rash over their entire body. This can last for up to a week. In rare cases, measles can lead to brain infection, blindness, and death. There is no specific treatment for measles.

Why am I hearing so much about measles?

Measles rates have been low in the United States since vaccination started in the 1960s. However, every year, there are a few cases that occur in unvaccinated persons. Often, these are related to international travel or contact with people who have recently traveled.

As of April 2025, the United States has had more than triple the cases of measles they had in all of 2024. Many cases are related to a large measles outbreak in Texas, although smaller outbreaks have been seen in Michigan and Ohio (among other states). Most people who have contracted measles in 2025 are unvaccinated or do not know if they were vaccinated.

Am I at risk for measles?

If you completed the vaccine series for measles (2 doses), you are immune and do not need further vaccinations. If you are not sure if you were vaccinated, ask your physician.

The United States began vaccinating military personnel in 1980. If you were in the military after that point, you were vaccinated against measles when you enlisted.

Do I need a repeat vaccination against measles?

At this time, if you have received 2 doses of measles vaccination, there are no recommendations for people to receive additional doses of measles vaccine. If you did not have 2 vaccines, please discuss whether you should receive additional vaccines with your primary care provider.

There is no test to determine if you are immune to measles or not. Antibody tests can be helpful if positive, but a negative does not mean you are able to contract measles.

If you have a severely weakened immune system, you do not need more vaccinations, but you should let your physician know right away if you find out you were exposed to measles.

